

China, Japan, and Southeast Asia



Magnolia (*Magnolia officinalis*, p. 232) relieves cramps and indigestion.

Baical skullcap (*Scutellaria baicalensis*, p. 134) is given for diarrhea.

Fu ling (*Poria cocos*) is a fungus that is dried, compressed, and cut into cubes. It increases energy levels.

Chou wu tong (*Clerodendrum trichotomum*, p. 191) is a valuable herb for the treatment of eczema.

Ginseng (*Panax ginseng*, p. 118) helps the body cope with stress and fatigue.

Ginseng decoction

Ginseng root

Schisandra (*Schisandra chinensis*, p. 133). The berries are eaten for 100 days as a tonic.

Sang ye (*Morus alba*, p. 237) alleviates the symptoms of flu.

Codonopsis (*Codonopsis pilosula*, p. 83) restores the appetite. In China, it is often added to soups and vegetable dishes.

Jing jie (*Schizonepeta tenuifolia*, p. 268) is prescribed for fevers and measles.

China's ancient herbal tradition has survived intact into the 21st century, and in China it is now accorded equal status with Western conventional medicine. Today, many Chinese universities teach and research herbal medicine, a factor of crucial importance in the reemergence of herbalism worldwide.

Traditional Chinese medicine (TCM) and the herbal tradition that is part of it developed separately from Chinese folk medicine. It arose from ideas recorded between 200 BCE and 100 CE in the *Yellow Emperor's Classic of Internal Medicine* (*Huang Di Nei Jing*). This text is based on detailed observations of nature and a deep understanding of the way that all life is subject to natural laws. It contains concepts that are fundamental to TCM, including *yin* and *yang*; the five elements (*wu xing*); and the theory of the effect of nature upon health.

In TCM, living in harmony with these principles is the key to good health and longevity. According to the *Yellow Emperor's Classic*, members of previous generations lived for a hundred years, and had constitutions so strong that illness was cured by incantations alone. Only later, as human vitality, or *qi*, declined and people became "overactive...going against the joy of life," did herbal medicine, acupuncture, and other branches of TCM become necessary.

Key Theories

Unlike other herbal traditions that have a unified theory for making sense of illness and disease (for example, the European theory of the four humors), TCM has two quite different systems—the *yin* and *yang* theory and the five elements. They developed quite separately in China, and the five elements system was only accepted and fully incorporated into Chinese



On the streets of Hong Kong herbal pharmacists are a familiar sight. Prescriptions are formulated during a consultation with an herbalist, and the patient then obtains the appropriate herbs.